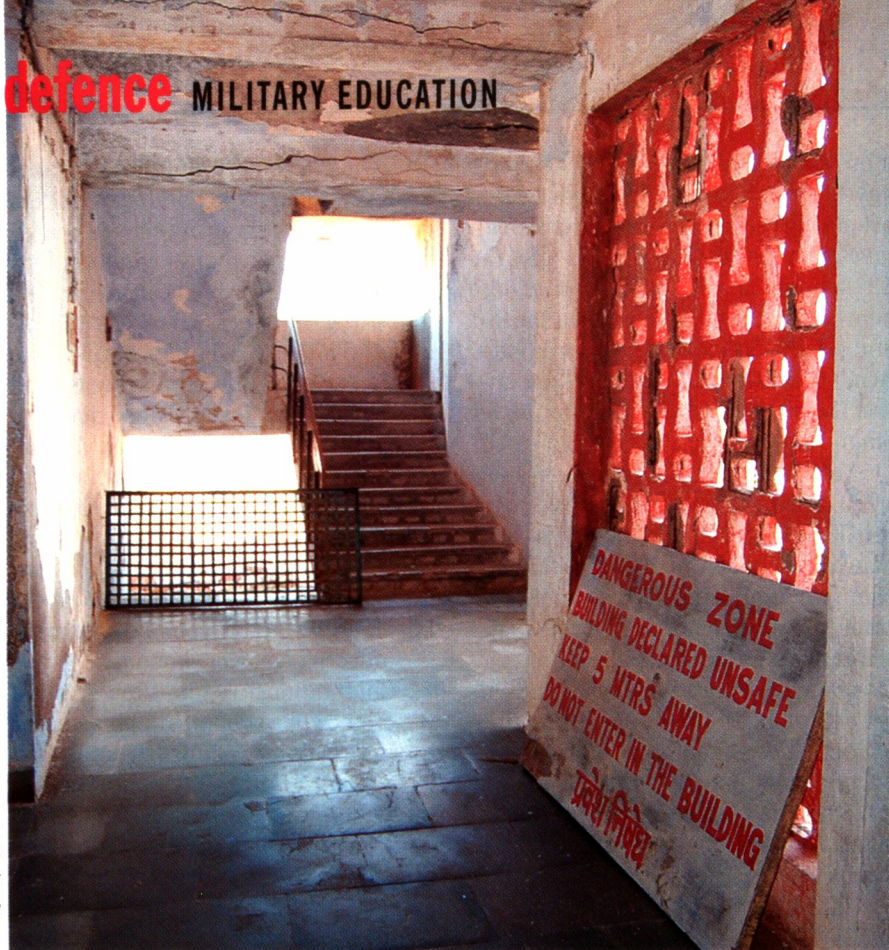




VISHWAS THAKKAR

FALLING APART: Sainik School, Balachadi, in Gujarat educational institution.

"The schools are assets of the state governments. However, the support that the states are giving is inadequate," says M.M. Pallam Raju, minister of state for defence. The government has categorised the support by states to nine schools as "inadequate", at the Kazhakootam and Satara schools as "grossly inadequate" while Madhya Pradesh has not given its Sainik School in Rewa a grant in the last 15 years. The schools, that cost Rs 20 crore are set up on the request of the state governments. MoD has approved three more in Mizoram, Sikkim and Jharkhand.

The main issue, ministry officials say, is that the Memorandum of Agreement (MOA), defining the liabilities of the states towards the schools, were not signed when these were set up decades back. With multiple centres responsible for their maintenance, administration and funding, responsibility is diffused, something which Raju says he is trying to rectify. "The onus of Sainik Schools has to be taken jointly by the Centre and states which is why we have sent out MOAs to all state governments," he says. So far, only Bihar,

Jharkhand and Karnataka have signed these but only for the new institutions, not the old ones.

Set up to address regional imbalances in the armed forces, the schools have today given rise to disparities of their own. While students pay the same fee all over the country, each state has different scholarship brackets (called full scholarships) to support students from a certain income group. While fee has been increasing, support from the states in the form of scholarships is stagnant. A cadet from Orissa whose parents' monthly income is Rs 1,500 would get Rs 12,000 annually from his state government to study in a Sainik School. However, a cadet from Uttarakhand in the same income bracket would get Rs 32,000 per year. "By accepting different yardsticks for different schools, we are inadvertently accepting regional inequities," says a senior government official.

Of its annual budget of Rs 2.4 crore, Sainik School, Kazhakootam, alone runs up a bill of Rs 1.6 crore on salaries. And all of this is borne by the cadets. Adding to their angst is the prospect of another hike in salaries and pensions of the school staff.

The Board of Governors (BOG) Headed by Defence Minister A.K.

Antony, and comprising Raju, the education secretary, the University Grants Commission chairman and vice-chiefs of staff of the armed forces has not met in over 10 years. "We have not found any substantive agenda to convene a meeting," admits a bureaucrat. With such apathy and dwindling recruits becoming a prime concern, an immediate solution say officials, would be to immediately place the schools under the MoD's Integrated Defence Staff which manages tri-service training institutions like the NDA. "The Centre should stop waiting for an upsurge of patriotism from the states," says a senior armed forces officer.

"The MoD should fund the schools and appoint retired military officers to run them for six-year terms as the present three-year tenures by serving officers is inadequate," says Vice-Admiral (retired) Vinod Pasricha.

It would cost the government Rs 50 crore, just 0.05 per cent of the Rs 1.05 lakh crore military budget, to run all the 22 Sainik Schools. At a time when the government is spending Rs 20,000 crore every year buying sophisticated defence hardware, it could well stop to think if it is doing enough to attract the personnel who will man these in future. ■

SOLUTIONS

- Get states to sign on Memorandums of Agreement (MoAs) where they agree to subsidise education. So far only 3 states have signed these.
- Scholarships to deserving students from the lower socio-economic strata should be hiked every year.
- If states cannot run the schools, MoD can take over and hand them to the Integrated Defence Staff which runs all joint training establishments like the NDA.
- The total cost of running all Sainik Schools at Rs 50 crore per year is half the cost of one Light Combat Aircraft or 0.05 per cent of the Rs 1.05 lakh crore defence budget.